



Unlike many traditional portraits, which stopped just below the shoulders, Lisa's dress and hands were also included. Leonardo clearly spent long hours re-creating the folds in her clothing and ensuring that the relaxed posture of her hands matched the peaceful expression on her face.

It is likely that Leonardo began painting the *Mona Lisa* in 1503, and he continued to work at it, on and off, for many years. One of the big mysteries surrounding the portrait is why the Giocondos never received it.

For all of his hard work, it seems that Leonardo never considered the portrait fully finished, so it remained in his possession for the rest of his life.

DID YOU KNOW?

The *Mona Lisa* is now in the French national art museum, the Louvre in Paris. The painting was famously stolen in 1911. It was recovered two years later.